"The fires of progress are fueled by the souls of damned."

-Francis Hardaventure

"Do you have any questions for us?" asked Ahmir Gosh.

"When can I start?" I chuckled, trying my best to mask my anxiety and desperation, with bad humor. Even I wasn't buying it.

He indulged me with a curt laugh, "The soonest we can start you is Monday, how does that sound?"

"That's perfect."

"Now." He let out a sigh. "Given your history the best I can offer you is minimum wage. At the end of your first six months, as long as everything goes smoothly, we can discuss a reasonable raise."

"That's not a problem, you are not going to regret this, Ahmir. Thank you."

"Mr. Gosh, please."

"Of course, thank you. Mr. Gosh."

I walked out of his office, into the night, beaming. I had been unemployed for so long that even a minimum wage janitor job made me feel like I was walking on air. I walked home, adding an extra 10 minutes to avoid the worst parts of the French Quarter. Although there was cause for celebration, this was not the night to be tempting fate.

"Ghatnychge" a man, dressed in some torn and stained white uniformed rags. He was pale and sickly, mumbling as I approached him.

"I'm sorry, I don't have any change." I sped up to step around him, but he matched me and blocked my path.

"Nythnglldo" he persisted.

"I'm sorry." I didn't know what else to say. I reached forward to softly push him out of the way, but he beat me to it. In an instant he had his hands on my shoulders and was pulling me in, snarling like a rabid dog. My instincts kicked in, and I hit him with a knee to the gut.

"I'm sorry," I apologized softly, pathetically, as he doubled over face first to the ground. He made no attempt to stop his head from connecting directly with the dirtied cobblestone. His mouth lay open, pushing and pulling a crushed cigarette butt as he took shallow, ragged breaths. I quickly walked away, not daring to turn around. I just hoped I hadn't hurt him too badly. He hadn't deserved that.

Brpphhhmmm.

A black van rounded the corner at a breakneck speed, bumping the curb and speeding back the way I had come. The force of the wind rocked me back onto my heels. "Damn, drunk tourists." I muttered to myself. The price of living in New Orleans, I suppose. A never-ending torrent of ever-changing faces. Each year more repugnant and disrespectful than the last. Our streets ran black with their vomit and piss. A thick miasma emanated from every street and alleyway. I could not imagine ever leaving; it was intoxicating.

The moment my head hit my pillow I slept. My mind was finally at ease, soon I would be able to pay my rent. I was coming up, leaving rock bottom in my rearview mirror.

"Come over here, look at this." She knelt in the grass, her head bent over slightly, gently letting locks of curly brunette hair fall over her shoulder and cover her face. Her hands cupped something in the grass, and she closed them together and pulled it up. I bent over. "Look," she said, as she carefully pulled her hands apart. A frog, a tiny frog. I had never seen a frog so small, no bigger than a penny. It cautiously made small hops over the surface of her hands, curiously exploring the giant's terrain. "Isn't it adorable." It was.

I awoke in a cold sweat. The light of a new day peered through the holes in my curtains.

People often imagine that those who have done something horrible are haunted by the memory of that final action. The nail in the coffin, the straw that broke the camel's back, the moment when something pure became tarnished, sullied: destroyed. That is not always the case. It was not the mistakes that flooded my mind and drowned my thoughts, it was the times that came before. The good times. The pleasant memories, jagged and dull knives that carved a bleeding scar every time they rose to the surface.

The remainder of my weekend was spent in preparation for my employment to come. I washed and pressed my only good shirt. I shaved my face and trimmed my hair. I

cleaned my tiny apartment and stared longingly at my empty cabinets and fridge, I hoped would soon be filled. I felt good, the promise of a new beginning always rose my spirits; though, my nights remained restless. After years, I had little hope of them ever being any other way.

"Welcome to hell, I'll be your guide on this journey. Remember to keep your arms and legs inside the vehicle at all times." He let out a laugh that shook the grotesque layers of fat that draped from his overburdened bones. "My name is Saul, Saul Garret, or as my friends call me, Saul the Janitor." Laughing to himself again, revealing a shining set of brown and crooked teeth. His breath, putrid, rotted onions and stale cigarettes, wafted with every wheezing exhale.

Saul grabbed my shoulder with one hand and stuck his other out expecting to shake my hand. His fingernails, yellowed, and his palms sheen with a dirty film of sweat, grease, and chemicals. I shook it and smiled. "Ted, Ted Johansson."

"Johansson, huh, you related to that uh, Scarlette woman. Nice pair on her. Ha." It seemed anything would set him off, more strained laughter erupted from his hole. "I'm just playin'. Why don't we get you into one of those uniforms over there and then I give you the grand tour." He gestured to a pile of stained dark grey rags spilling out of an overflowing dirty hamper, like boiling tar bubbling out of the ground, slowly consuming.

"Great," I said, half smiling. I had come too far to allow myself to be pushed away by such, ultimately, begrudgingly, inconsequential things. It was a steady paycheck and, more importantly, it was a purpose. I bent over and picked up one of the rags, Saul showed no intention of giving me any privacy, so I did not bother asking. I could feel his eyes bearing into my back as I turned to remove my shirt. He inhaled quickly but made no comment.

"Now, why don't you follow me, and I'll show what's what." Saul said.

We exited the cramped janitors' quarters and began to explore the interior. It was so much larger than I had ever expected it to be. After we had gone down three or four floors, I stopped trying to orient myself, there was no hope. There seemed to be no end to the stacked grid of white, fluorescent halls, small offices and storage spaces filling the areas in between.

"Right about now, you're probably thinking to yourself that there is no way on God’s good green Earth that you are ever gonna remember even the slightest bit where you are happened to be presently located. And you're goddamned right." More waves cascaded

along his neck and stomach as he let out yet another belly laugh. The almost unbearably clean scent of the halls was gone in an instant and replaced with his, far more unbearable, breath. How is it that a man, who took such pride in his work, cleaned with such religious fervor, as one must to keep a building this impossibly clean, completely disregard his own personal hygiene to such a degree that it made you wonder how he even managed to stay alive at all.

"Where is everybody?" I had only just now noticed the complete lack of any signs of life in the halls. Until this point it had seemed perfectly natural, it was hard to imagine any living, breathing person sullying the sanctity of this bleached dungeon.

"Ah, they work at night. They leave, we clean, then we leave and then they come back. You get it?" He spoke with bemused, nauseating arrogance, as if I was the stupidest person in the world.

We continued our journey to two more floors, each identical to the last, down to the last floor tile. Until we reached the, what I could only blindly guess at this point, was the southern side of the lowest floor. There, at the end of the hall, stood a blueish gray double door. The window on each door was remarkably black, as though you could reach down into it, forever and ever, and never feel it reach back. As we approached the door the light in the hallway also began to fade, dimming with each step, as if light itself dared not approach that door. The hallway grew chilly.

"And that's all there is to it. Not too bad, the people are all really clean, don't ever make too much of a mess for us." Saul had stopped about 6 feet from the double doors.

"What about back there?" I said, motioning to the doors.

"Oh that, thats the warehouse." Saul said.

"Don't we need to clean in there?" I asked.

"Nope, its all automated. They got some fancy robots in there, doin all the heavy liftin."

"But what about the bathrooms?"

"They're robots, don't leak nothin' but oil." Saul said no longer amused by my apparent stupidity.

"It's so dark," I said completely transfixed, my gaze, locked on the doors.

Saul turned to look at me. "What part of robots do you not understand. I knew you was a drunk," I winced," but I thought you'd had at least a few screws knocking around in that

noggin of yours. Robots don't need lights to see. They just move around with their fancy computers and radar gizmos."

"Now, let's get back upstairs and get you a mop and a bucket." He took me by the shoulder and faked a sniffle, "Its almost enough to make a grown man cry, seeing another man gettin' his first mop, a mon-num-mentous occasion!" He laughed and wheezed and laughed.

Saul was right about one thing; the employees were unfathomable clean. I actually felt like I was making the place dirtier just by being there. It took us no time at all to have the place sparkling. Saul spent the rest of his shift snoring with deafening intensity in the janitor's closet.

With no peace to be found in there, I went out and began to wander the halls.

I took this way and that, willing myself to get lost. Though try as I might, my wandering was anything but aimless. Every step drew me closer. I didn't know what it was, remaining, nagging human curiosity, a primal need to have my questions answered, secrets revealed. My pace quickened with each floor.

I arrived at the basement, panting, almost out of breath, I had taken the last steps. 3 or 4 at a time, gripping the handrail, white knuckled and sweaty. After I caught my breath I leaned back, ready to sprint the rest of the way, when something caught my eye. Just in my periphery. Down the hall perpendicular to the stairs, there was something on the ground. My focus shifted, the doors slipped away, and the tiny black spot now held my full attention. I turned toward it and began to approach.

The spot remained motionless and indistinguishable. I inched forward, barely daring to breathe. If this had been any other building, I would have considered my behavior extreme, maybe borderline crazy. But as of yet, I had not seen even a single spec of dirt that hadn't been tracked in on my own shoes or crusted onto Saul's fat.

It moved. I was only 10 or so feet from it now, but it was still too small to tell, maybe it was just a fly. I took another step, and another, and another. Just as I was beginning to make it out, it crawled, no, hopped, away. It was a frog. Tiny and black, slick with shiny coat that reflected the fluorescent lights of the hall like a brilliant diamond.

I froze. The frog hopped around a corner and out of sight. I didn't know exactly what they did here, but I couldn't imagine a use for a frog. I wondered if it was possible that one of us had tracked it in. I pursued.

Rounding the corner I quickly scanned the spotless tiles hoping to catch another glimpse. My breath caught in my throat. Standing, motionless, at the end of the hall was a woman, head to toe in white. Her skin matched the floors and walls, bleached and sickly. Lines, or tattoos covered the backs of her arms and legs, like her skin was splitting at the seams, cracked and broken.

I tried to regain composure, there was no reason to be shocked, this was an office, I was bound to run into people eventually. I called out, "Excuse me." She remained motionless. Maybe she just hadn't heard me. "Excuse me," I spoke louder this time, trying to get her attention but not frighten her. I thought for a moment I saw her muscles clench and tighten. I cautiously started to approach her.

Brrrttt, brrt.

The silence shattered. The lights shut off for an instant then began to flash red. The hallways filled with a blaring alarm. The sound was suffocating, my hands shot to cover my ears in a futile attempt to muffle the pain. There was no use, my knees buckled, and I fell to the ground, my vision blurred, and I shut my eyes. My senses, overwhelmed by the flashing lights and unrelenting alarm.

I remembered the woman. I forced open my eyes for a second, just long enough to see her being dragged away. Two men, dressed in some of protective hazmat suit, held her by her shoulders. She didn't seem to be resisting, limply resigned to her fate, unquestionably accepting. My eyes shut and I fully collapsed.

I felt a light kick to my side. "Wakey, wakey, sleepy head." I felt another kick to my side; I exhaled deeply and my eyes fluttered open. My vision was hazy and out of focus, there was, "What happened," I said with panting urgency as I struggled to regain consciousness.

"Well, the way I figure it, you saw that I was taking my little mid-shift break and thought it would be a good time to sneak away from your boss's watchful, righteous, eye, to have yourself a little drink."

"That's not..."

"... then one drink turned to two, and soon enough yous was stumblin your way through the halls can't tell which way your ass is from up, you tip over your own two feet, decide the cold tile is a nice place for nap and you drift away to dream land."

"Men, wha-at about the men?"

"Listen, cause I just happen to be a God fearin' man I'm gonna let this first one slide, but if you keep talking crazy, 'bout men and who knows what, I'm gonna haul your ass right out of this building. You understand me?";

"The alarm… Did you hear the alarm? The lights?" I was standing now, I had grabbed ahold of his shoulders and held him in front of me, but my eyes were still transfixed on the spot where they had dragged her away. Her.

I saw his gaze shift to my hand, uncomfortably resting on his shoulder. "I don't know what brand of manure you think you're shovelin' but I don't want to smell another bit of it. Men, alarms, flashing red lights, sounds like you were talkin about some kinda alien, coming down here in his flying saucer. I hate to break it ya' but we are about 7 storeys underground, the only aliens in here is the two of us. Now, I'm writin this off as a mix of hangover and acute head trauma, so why don't ya go back upstairs get your things and go home to sleep it off. I'll see you back here tomorrow night sober as a door nail."

"But I wasn't…"

"I don't want to hear it. I'm only gonna tell you this one more time, go home, sober up and get some rest. I ain't tellin' nobody about this, so long as it doesn't happen again."

"Bu…"

"Go. Home."

I finally took the hint.

Work became an uneventful blur, a world passing by my window, detached, indistinguishable, boring. Days turned to weeks and weeks turned to months. Although I had never grown to seek out the company of Mr. Saul the Janitor, I had begun to tolerate him, almost.

"I ain't sayin' that I don't appreciate a big hunk o' junk in the trunk, all I'm sayin' is that something that just ain't all there is to it. Now I seen some pretty ladies who was packing heat, if you know what I mean, but sometimes, that just ain't enough."

"Mhmm," I made a small nod, as though I had been listening to anything he had said in the last hour. *smack,* the impact from the waded paper ball was enough to snap me out of the hypnotic state I had unknowingly slipped into, neither conscious nor awake, thoughtlessly tossing a ball of paper up and down, up and down, up. And down.

I snapped upright.

“The feminine figu…” Saul droned on, unaware or uncaring of the sudden motion from my cot. Then, faintly, buried beneath the endless torrent of sewage coming from Saul’s mouth, there was another sound. A low, quiet beeping. The alarm. I got to my feet.

“Now where do you think you are going?” Saul’s attention, surprisingly captured by something I had done.

“Don’t you hear it?” I said.

“Hear what?”

“Shh. Listen.”

We both stayed there, straining. Then, there it was again. *Brrttt, brrrtttt.* Barely more than a whisper, a deaf cry through the walls.

“It’s the alarm, the alarm I was telling you about. I am going to go check it out.” I started to move towards the door. I was reaching for the handle, when I felt Saul’s sweaty hand wrap around my arm.

“Now just hold on a moment, we ain’t the Hardy boys, they don’t pay us to go around looking for clues and solvin mysteries.

“We have to go see what’s wrong, it could be a fire. There might be someone down there that needs our help.”

I looked at Saul, his eyes were squinted, strained. The old and rusted cogs of his brain doing their best to try and compute this unforeseen situation. He could tell that I was right this time, and maybe I saw a little curious light ignite behind his bloodshot eyes.

“Alright, you just wait here, and I’ll go see what all the ruckus is about.”

“I want to come with you.”

“I said, wait. Now, you know I don’t like pullin’ the seniority card left and right, but I am your boss, and you will do what I tell you to do.”.

“But…”

“I don’t want to hear another word about it. I am going and you are stayin’. I’ll be right back, and I’ll tell you all about the aliens down there looking for an ass to probe.“ He laughed.

That was the end of it, I knew better than to argue with Saul. Despite his myriad of flaws, he was steadfast and once he had made a decision he did not waver. He opened the

door and for a moment I could hear the alarm clear and sharp, before the door was shut and I was left to nothing but my own imagination.

I sat there in silence, listening to the faint alarm. Seconds seemed to crawl by, elongated by my own anxiety and anticipation. The old clock on the wall seemed tick slower with every passing second. I could feel my breath quickening, or time slowing. After five minutes, the alarm stopped, but my worry was unabated.

After 15 minutes, Saul had not returned and I decided I had had enough of waiting. I grabbed my flashlight, for no other reason to the feel the weight of something in my hands, and went out. The light was blinding, but not flashing red, white, argressively tranquil. I glanced up and down the hall before I set off.

I moved slowly at first, cautiously, I don't know what I kept expecting see beyond each corner, but I assumed it would be something I had no desire to see. With each floor my pace quickened, not yet frantic but enamored by curiousty. I had never known Saul to spend more time in an upright position than he needed to. When I reached the bottom floor, I knew he had to be nearby there was no where he could have gone. I passed one of the alarm lights, and I stopped breathless and staring expecting to once again erupt.

I cleared the whole floor and Saul was nowhere to be found. There was no indication of anything either. The floors and walls reflected their usual nothingness. I was about to chalk it up to Saul having forgotten to come back and report, when I remembered the doors at the end of the hall. I had spent so much time ignoring them, that I had almost forgetten they were there at all. I turned around and ran.

I put my hand on the handle and turned, trying my best to quite the voice in my head that told me that this was a bad idea. I opened the door and felt a rush of cool air burst through. The initial cool breeze felt nice, reassuring, but that feeling was quickly replaced by disgust. Overpowering chemical fumes engulfed me, forcing themselves inside of me. This was not the same chemical smell that had filled the halls every day I had been here, bleach and vinegar. This was something different.

I was remind of middle school, 8th grade science class. Half the class beaming with excitment and the other half green and repulsed. The teacher stood at the front of the class holding a small vaccum sealed bag, a baby pig curled up inside. The flimsy, pastic womb did nothing to mask the unmistakable, putrid smell: formaldehyde.

I was so taken aback, I had forgotten what I was doing there in the first place. Saul, I turned my head and took a deep breathe before I started to walk inside. I turned on my flashlight, half expecting to see some creature from the black lagoon in a large illuminate

vat, bobbing up and down. But what I saw somehow was more shocking, I had never imagined it. Behind the closed doors was a warehouse.

I was standing on a cat walk, high above rows and rows and rows of tall metal shelves. The soft beam of my flashlight could barely reach the floor, the shelves seemed to almost extend into another bottomless abyss. Something moved down there, I saw it, for a brief second, pass between two rows of the shelves, to dark and distant to distinguish. A robot? No I had a feeling although this was a warehouse, there was more going on here.

"Saul!" I called out. Only a faint echo responded.

I turned my flashlight to the side and to my luck, I saw a small metal staircase, spiralling into the darkness below. I went towards, making a mental note of the fact that the door had closed itself behind me, shuttering as I imagined it never pulling open again.

I took the stairs two at a time, fully committed, I had come oto far to let my fear get the best of me. When I reached the bottom of the stairs the darkness seemed more oppressive than I had thought possible from above. The beam of my light seemed to do no more than butter knife cutting through steak. With no direction I started heading down the first aisle, running searching for anything at all.

I turned a corner and almost crashed into something. I fell to my feet, and looked up. Standing there was a person. The last thing I had expected to see. They were walking holding a large cardboard box, undetered by my presence, as if they hadn't even noticed I was there. I called out to them, but again as met with only my own echo. I stood up and tried to tap them on the shoulder, shake them out of the trance. Anything to garner their attention, but they remained focused, focused and determined to deliver their box. I ran in front of them, playing chicken, I would not move. They walked towards me then took one step to the side and walked around me, completely aware of my presence but uncaring.

"Hey," I was shouting now, to no avail. I saw no other option but to follow them and see where they were going with such resolution. They turned this way and that navigating the maze of shelves as if they were driving the streets of their hometown, born and raised knowning every curve.

They turned around another shelf, and I followed, beyond there were more, more people. They all had boxes and they were loading and unloading them into a large freight elevator. Passing by one another without so much as a nod or a glance in each others direction.

"Hey!" I shouted again, hoping to pull the attention of even just one of them, but it was useless. I walked into the crowd, holding my flashlight close to each one, examining

them. Their skin was pale and covered in a spiderweb of black lines, as if all their blood had been replaced with tar. Their eyes were empty and white, unfeeling and unknowing. Each one dressed head to toe in pale, sterile garments. I walked between them, there had to be two or three dozen, everytime another one stepped out into the labyrthn emptyhanded, another emerged from the black, holding a box.

Then I saw her step out from the abyss, into my faint light. Her hair thin, dark and curled. I ran towards her, pushing my way through the silent crowd. She was just like them, focused, driven by some invisble force, carrying an unmarked cardboard box. Her skin, white and sickly, tattooed with black viens.

But she was also different. Different because I knew her. Underneath the diseased faccade, she was unmistakeable. I had spent years staring into her eyes, learning the subtlies of her face and even longer replaying them in my mind. I reached out.

"Sar-"

In an instant I was pulled back. Iron hands grasped my every limb, I was torn away. My flash light fell to the floor and went out. I was surrounded by darkness, consumed, and trapped. I struggled with every bit of strength that I could muster but it was futile. There was no escaping. I had made a mistake coming in here, I knew that now, and it was too late.

I heard the click of a door handle and the light returned. I was thrown into a chair and felt no urge to try and stand up. Instead I looked around and tried to determine where I had been taken. It was not a cell, far from it, it looked like an office. The office of someone very important. The chair was an antique, carefully polished dark wood. Cushoned with a forest green felt, soft and aged, I can't remember if I had ever sat in a chair this nice. To each of my sides there stood one of them. I was hesitant to call them people now, maybe robots was the best word for them. I knew better than to ask them where they had taken me.

I was in front of a wooden desk, like the chair it was polished and smooth. Unblemeshied and nicer than any I had seen. Behind the desk was a wall of books, some of them new and fresh, others, ancient and worn, their titles unintelligiable, faded. In the center of the bookshelf was a glass case, like an aquarium, only it wasn't filled with water. There vibrant greens and browns, the glass was covered in dew, a moist tropical world lay there, seperated by a thin pane of glass. I strained my eyes to search the interior, looking for something, though I was not sure what.

I heard the door click open again, and I turned to see who, I assumed was the owner and resident of this office, was. It was a man, tall, and black. He was dressed head to toe in white, although not the hospital garments I had seen on all the others. It was a suit, much like the halls of this building, bleached and blinding, freshly pressed and without so much as a spot of dirt. He was in charge, I had no doubt.

He flashed a perfect, brilliant smile. "Ted," he said, as if he was greeting an old friend, "welcome my friend. Welcome, to the other side."

His accent was thick, creole. I had never adopted the accent myself, but over the years I had become very familiar. There was something beautifully strange about it, haphazardly evolved over hundreds of years of forced integration, of dozens of cultures and languages. It was harsh and distinct but comforting.

"Now, I am sure you have many questions,"

"How is she here?" I didn't care that I was interrupting him, I needed to know.

He laughed, softly and warm, "Please, I will answer all your questions, in due time." He paused, waiting to see if I would say something else.

"First, I would like to tell you a story, the story of my ancestors." He took a sip of a water.

"Excuse me, where are my manners, would like you something to drink, coffee, tea, water?" I said nothing, he looked at one of the figures standing beside me, "Jeffery would you please get this gentleman, a nice cool, glass of water. I am sure he is parched after his adventure today." Jeffery, as it had been called, blindly obeyed, expression unwavering, eyes pale and unfocused.

"Please, drink, there is no reason to be afraid." He smiled.

"Now, as I am sure you are aware, the number of black people who entered this country willingly in the 1700's is, let's say, small. My family was torn from their homeland, their people, their culture and way of life and forced into a life of tortured servitude. In that time there was very little hope to found. When you can be beaten or killed for spilling wine or learning to read, there is very little hope indeed. However, some of us, we chose not to be broken down by this barbiac system of oppression, but to embrace on to our heritage and rise above it. To tap into ancient powers that the white man dared not touch."

"Of course, I am talking about voodoo." I couldn't help but to scoff. Voodoo was nothing more than tale told to tourists to goad them into buying overly priced dolls and hex bags, dreaming of a life where their problems could be wished away. That was not how the

world works. He smiled again and turned toward the glass case. He peered inside for a moment, searching as I was but moments ago.

"Who is this woman you mentioned earlier." His abrut change, caught me off guard.

"Sa-Sarah," I stuttered, somehow barely able to get the words out.

"And you say you saw her down here? Why is that so concerning? Isn't it nice to see an old friend, an ex-lover?" This time his smile felt sharp and purposeful.

"It's not possible," I said, "she can't be here."

"Why not," his tone changed, it was agressive, powerful. He knew.

"She... she died, years ago."

"And how, did she die?"

Now I was getting angry, "That doesn't matter, she's gone, buried."

He chuckled again, I clenched my fists. He turned back to the case.

"Aha, there he is," He gestured to a small black spot stuck to the glass. "The prized jewel of the bayou. Many men go their who lives unaware of it's exsistence, even modern science does not acknoledge its presence. It has no scientific name, but in some circles it is refered to as the frog mortis aeternae. The frog of eternal death. It is beautiful isn't it, the way the light glistens on it's skin, like a diamond."

"It is funny, in your western media, the fountain of youth, the holy grail, these stories, they all talk of eternal life. A state of being where you are no different than you are now, but forever. But this is not possible, it is purely fantasy. Nothing can exist without change, you know this better than many. It is essential to the progression of the world, a unbiased force of nature, where nothing can remain as it was, for better, or for worse."

I took another sip of water, my mouth had become uncomfortably dry.

"Many talk of death as the end, that there is nothing beyond that final door we sped our entire lives trying not to open. But death is a transitory state, a single moment that stands between living and decay. What this frog can do, if used properly is prolong that state, capture the body after the soul has left but before nature can do its damage."

"That's impossible." I said.

"I thought so once."

"When I was a young boy, growing up deep in the bayou, there was very little to go around, but that didn't stop my mother and father. I had 9 brothers and sisters, its hard to imagine nowadays but that was not uncommon back then. My parents, depsite their flaws, loved us all very much, more than many others I knew. When I was just 10 years old, my younger sister, Janet, she became very sick. We didn't have access to any medical care, and if we did, we wouldn't have been able to afford it."

I coughed.

"We did the best we could, we cared for her, brought here everything she needed, but sometimes, that is just not enough. Eventually my mother couldn't stand it anymore, she was desperate. She said her mother knew somebody, somebody who could help. She made the call."

"By the time they had arrived it was too late, my sister had passed."

"I'm sorry," I said.

"Thank you, but that is not the end of the story. My sister was dead, yes, but the woman who arrived she said we could bury her and try our best to move on, or there was another option. Deep in the swamp there was a frog, a species that had a special property, when combined with the correct ritual, it could bring her back. Now the woman warned my mother, she said that she would not be the same, but my mother didn't care, she told her to do it."

"And so she did. She wouldn't allow anyone to watch, anyone, except me. She said there was somethign different about me, something special." "So I watched, with carefuly intesnity, determined to understand and when the ritual was over, I stood by sisters side. I stood there for three days and three nights. On the third night she started to breathe again, it was a miracle, she had return to the land of the living."

"Or so we had thought, as time went on we started to realise that she would not be returning as she had been, just as the woman from the woods had warned us. She could stand up and she could move on her own, but her eyes, they were pale and white, faded and unfeeling. Eventually my father had had enough and took her out to the bayou and I never saw her again,"

"But I never forgot."

"What are you saying?" I asked.

"At the beginning of this life we are a dealt a hand, some of them easier to play than others but we are all given something. I decided to use what I had been given."

"Even though my sister had not been the same when she came back, she had not been entirely useless. She was able to follow strict instruction and when properly fed, she had as much energy as the rest of us. She would cook and clean right along side my mother and sisters."

"As I grew older, like anyone, I started to dream big. I wanted more for myself than this life I had been given, I wanted money and power. As I planned my rise to power, I began to reflect on my life, on the cards I had been dealt. It was at that time that I realized the lucky hand I had been given."

"A close friend of mine, Jeffrey," to my side, "came down with cancer, stage 4, terminal. There was no way out for him, he saw the light at the end of the tunnel and it was coming for him. In his final days, I stayed by his side, I listened to him talk about all the things he wished he had done, about the life he had yet to live, about his impact, or lack thereof, on the world."

"These are things we often have a hard time considering until we are staring down the barrel of the gun. But it gave me an idea. I thought back to my sister, I thought of how my father had been rash. Perhaps my sister could have lived a life afterall, or at least served some sort of a purpose, and maybe Jeffrey could too."

"I sought after the woman from the woods, the woman had brought my sister back. She was frail and old, time had not been kind to her, but she took me in and she taught me, taught me everything she knew. The longer I spent with her the more my vision, my purpose, became clear. I could see the path and I knew I had to do."

"It was not pretty but I was getting it done. I had discovered an entirely new labor force, a force that worked for free, required nothing but the scraps from your table. For so long we had been burying our most valuable resource."

I couldn't listen any more, if what he was saying was true it was the greatest affront to nature, it was inconcievable and onforgiveable, "What are you saying, you are making an army of zombie slaves?"

"Ha. I wouldn't put it in such crass terms but essentially, yes, I suppose that I am."

"You are despicable those are people,"

"They were people. Now they are something more, they are serving a purpose greater than themselves. Would you rather than just be tossed away, discarded like some common piece of trash."

"No... I don't... It's wrong."

"It's the future. These aren't machines, they can be taught, they can learn, they obey."

"It's just not right." I couldn't seem to find the words, my head was spinning.

"22 years. 22 years Saul has worked for me and not once has he asked questions. He has done what he has been asked and he has stayed out of the doors. But 3 months with you and now he has had to go and join them."

"What do you mean."

"Now," He ignored my question, he knew I knew what he meant, "I am going to offer you a choice, because I like you, and because I need someone on the other side."

I found it difficult to keep my head raised, my attention was faltering.

"I will let you walk out of here, as long as you agree to assume the responisbilities of Saul, without question. Or you can join, Sarah, down there on the floor. The decision is yours, and I expect you act quickly. The posion in your drink acts quickly."

I looked down out the glass, my focus going in and out. I said nothing. I saw him turn again, and reach into the case, he pulled out one of the frogs and held it, cupped in his, in front of me. It was no bigger than a penny, adorable, tiny and free